

7-Day China Itinerary Template

Beijing → Xi'an → Shanghai — A tested, efficient route for first-time visitors. Routes, budget breakdown, pre-trip checklist, and insider tips.

The core logic: Fly into Beijing → Train to Xi'an → Fly to Shanghai. Three cities, seven days, zero regrets.

Day-by-Day Breakdown

Day 1 — Beijing: Temple of Heaven + Wangfujing

Arrive at PEK or PKX. Take subway or Didi to hotel. Morning: Temple of Heaven before 8 AM (watch locals do tai chi). Evening: Wangfujing Street — try candied hawthorn berries.

Day 2 — Beijing: Forbidden City + Jingshan + Houhai

Enter Forbidden City via Tiananmen Gate (bring passport, allow 3-4 hours). Climb Jingshan Park for the iconic overhead view. Evening: Houhai lakeside — Yanjing beer and local karaoke.

Day 3 — Beijing: Great Wall (Mutianyu)

Skip Badaling. Mutianyu: 70 km from city, cable car available, less crowded. Book via official site or reputable operator. Avoid 'free ride' solicitors at subway stations.

Day 4 — Xi'an: Terracotta Army

Take Fuxing Hao high-speed train from Beijing (4.5 hrs, ~\$85). Arrive, drop bags near South Gate. Visit Terracotta Army before 9 AM or after 3 PM. Don't miss the bronze chariots.

Day 5 — Xi'an: City Wall + Big Wild Goose Pagoda + Muslim Quarter

Rent a bike on the ancient City Wall (14 km loop, ~2 hrs, start at South Gate). Afternoon: Big Wild Goose Pagoda. Evening: Muslim Quarter — lamb biangbiang noodles, roujiamo, osmanthus cake.

Day 6 — Shanghai: The Bund + Nanjing Road + Yu Garden

Fly Xi'an → Shanghai (~2 hrs, \$80-120) or take high-speed rail (6 hrs). Morning: The Bund at sunrise. Midday: Nanjing Road pedestrian street. Afternoon: Yu Garden and old streets. Evening: Bund night lights.

Day 7 — Shanghai: French Concession + Jade Buddha Temple + Departure

Morning walk in the French Concession — tree-lined streets, lane houses, cafes. Jade Buddha Temple (45 min). Depart from PVG (international, allow 3 hrs) or SHA (domestic).

Quick-Reference Budget (per person, 7 days)

Item	Budget	Mid-Range	Comfort
Hotel / night (dbl)	\$25-40	\$60-120	\$200+
Meals / day	\$10-20	\$25-50	\$80+
Transport (7 days)	\$50-80	\$100-150	\$200+
Attractions (all)	\$40-60	\$80-120	\$120+
Total (7 days)	\$560-840	\$1,050-1,750	\$2,500+

Note: Excludes international flights. Prices are 2026 estimates in USD.

Pre-Trip Checklist

- ■ Valid passport (6+ months validity, blank pages)
- ■ China tourist visa (L-visa) OR confirm 144-hour visa-free transit eligibility
- ■ Onward / return flight confirmation (print + offline copy)
- ■ Hotel booking confirmations for every city
- ■ Alipay & WeChat Pay activated before arrival (no Chinese bank needed)
- ■ VPN installed and active before arrival (Gmail, Google, WhatsApp blocked)
- ■ eSIM or international roaming plan for data
- ■ 500-1,000 RMB cash for small vendors and temples
- ■ Travel insurance covering China
- ■ Offline maps (Google Maps won't work; download Maps.me or Baidu)

Insider Tips from Joran

- High-speed rail: Book via 12306 app (English version) or at station counter. Beijing→Xi'an 4.5 hrs.
- Payment: Alipay Tour Card and WeChat Pay support foreign cards now. Activate before you land.
- Internet: NordVPN or Astrill consistently work. Install and test before arrival — you can't download VPN apps inside China.
- Taxis: Use Didi (Chinese Uber) with English interface. Don't flag regular taxis as a first-timer.
- Great Wall: Mutianyu for convenience, Jinshanling for wild wall with zero crowds (2.5 hrs each way).
- Xi'an food: Eat in the Muslim Quarter, not near the Terracotta Army museum (overpriced and mediocre).
- Shanghai: The Bund at sunrise is empty and magical; night lights turn on around 7 PM.

Editorial note: This itinerary is a planning template based on research and on-the-ground experience. Prices, opening hours, and policies can change. Always verify against official sources before travel. More guides at chinaboundtravel.com

— ChinaBound Travel editorial team